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India has always watched General Pervez Musharraf with fascination. From the time he threw Nawaz Sharif out of office in October 1999 and assumed command as both President and Chief of Army Staff of Pakistan, the General has always seemed sure-footed. Even after 9/11, he positioned himself as a military ruler who would partner the United States in their war against terror.

At home, Musharraf was a strong leader who could maintain the equilibrium between civil society, the military and the mullahs. Much to his credit, he walked the tightrope of power well while dodging the bullets of his assassins. But now the foxy General is rapidly running out of tricks.

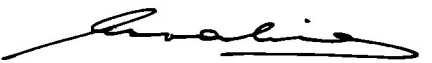
He has gradually alienated every section of society. Unleashing the army on extremists in north-west Pakistan has been a monumental error as 300 army men are now held captive. His negotiations with former premier Benazir Bhutto have left his loyalists in PML(Q), the King's Party formed by Musharraf, uncertain of their future. The storming of the Lal Masjid has angered the mullahs. By suspending chief justice Ifikhar Chaudhry, he has turned the once docile judiciary into a ferocious adversary.

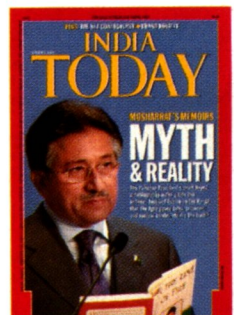
Time is running out for Musharraf; his term ends in November and general elections are also due soon after. In the face of crumbling authority, he is trying to stay President and General. Should he give up his position as General, then under the Pakistani Constitution he cannot remain President unless Parliament amends the law. Should he give up the uniform, he will become a target for the military man who takes over as the head of the army.

Naturally now, Pakistan's old political hands have spotted the opportunity to stake another claim to power. The exiled Sharif and Bhutto have both declared their intention to return home and court arrest. India will be interested in seeing what happens in Pakistan next because, democracy or military rule, it is in India's interest to have political stability in Pakistan. We know they shelter Kashmiri militants and other Islamic terrorists. Continuing instability and uncertainty will give such elements a free rein and serious trouble could spill over across the borders.

Our cover story this week is put together by our regular contributor in Karachi, Hasan Zaidi. Zaidi had recorded the deterioration of Musharraf's power and predicted the fall of the General. Former Indian high commissioner to Pakistan G. Parthasarathy writes a guest column about what the developments in Pakistan mean for India.

History shows that all dictatorships end messily. There are no orderly transitions. And so it seems with Musharraf. The end game has begun and his willingness to align himself with his old rival Bhutto shows his desperation. The crafty General and former paratrooper will require all his survival skills in the coming months.


(Aroon Purie)



Our Oct 2006 cover